Walk

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Chapter 1

This Walk

(Thud) (Thud) (Thud)

My old and janky car is shaking in the road like a high elephant, turning my stomach towards a feeling of inwardness. The sunlight wisps an oddly gentle gleam in the distance, the dampness slowly steams away, as the slight warmth of the morning sun begins to rise above the treeline. Yet, I am soo displeased at the performance of my basic and old car. Shouldn't cars be able to handle dirt roads?

Oh, man. This is ridiculous. (Thud) Ahhhhrrrrrrr!!!!! Stupid car! I will definitely replace you tonight. Yelling at my heap of replaceable trash, I see the sign of the hiking trail. It was so distinctive. A stiff square in the realm of fluid life. That sign looked like any weathered metal sign. So, I turned my worthless car to the tunnel of trees. Damp, dark, and full of the chirping of birds, so numerous that they all sound as if they were one.

As I drove along the bumpy and weathered dirt road, I shook like a wet dog; it felt intense. I could feel the bumps, yet I could not distinguish one bump from another. It all felt like one continuous shaking, and a shaking that I knew would be bad for my terrible car. Good. Finally, after what felt like years of strife, I finally made it to the parking lot of the hiking trail. Well, more or less, the parking lot is more like the end of the dirt road rather than an actual place to park. I could see the metal sign behind my car; it slightly gleamed in the morning sunlight. Dawn was

approaching, yet dawn is always approaching.

Ahhuuuhhhhh….. I hope that my wife might be less angry after this. She is such a pain to be around sometimes. As I turned my dull head, I caught the sunlight gleaming on the window of my car. It was a warm light. Warm. Yes, warm it is…. I couldn't help myself as I moved my hand to unlock my old car door, and then the old car door opened. As it opened, the calm, yet breezy feeling wind entered into the atmosphere of my car.

I decided to step out of the terrible car and immediately turned around to witness a brown casing all over my car. Oh yeah! I can't wait to replace this worthless car! It is 20 years old, and it has become a shameful beater, only worthy of being thrown away.

Gleefully, I turned around to stray away from such disgust. I then slowly looked up, and saw the weathered trees. Weathered. Damp. Muddy. Yes. Muddy, but not too muddy. The mud was wet, but wet like a thawed burrito, not like a wet burrito. Yet, the forest was inviting enough for me to begin to walk towards the trail.

As I walk toward the rustic trail entrance, I can see the worn-out hiking sign becoming clearer. It looks damaged, as if the damage is recent or old. I have no idea. I can see the pale inners of the wooden planks of the sign. The map is worn, but it looks like it might be intelligible. I guess I should head over to the map. As I get closer and closer to the map, I carefully try to avoid the various muddy areas around me. I imagine that I look like a drunk ostrich out in a dry outback whilst jumping over these worthless mud ponds.

Yet, with a soft difficulty, I eventually reached the map. Looking at the map in the breezy fall wind, within the various colors of the trees, it was clear. The map was too faded to tell me anything. Oh, old trails. They are always neglected. Within my stomach, I felt a sense of shared understanding with the trail, but I cannot put my finger on what exactly. Yet, before I knew it, my feet were moving, one after the other in the bird chirping colorful woods that lay before me.

Moving through the damp forest is a sight indeed. Patches of mud are meeting me at every turn. It is so annoying. Yet, the chirps of the woods, both calming and giving me ear pains, at least give me some sense of relaxation. As I lunged forward, I desperately tried to step on the piles of fallen leaves to keep my white shoes clean. As I navigated my way through the rustic trail, I looked up to see the fall colors.

Some trees were bare of leaves, some still had their leaves, most of them were tall, sturdy trees. Sturdy. Yet, within a ground that looks soft to the touch. Huh? What's that? ……. In the distance, it looks like I can see fall trees leaning onto the hill downward like a sloth holding onto an old tree. Looking around the damp environment, it feels ancient, and weirdly lonely. Yet, I cannot put my finger on why it is so. It just felt so.

Maybe it is because of my argument with my wife this morning? She was soo… inconsiderate. I mean, I woke up, made her oatmeal, and started her favorite YouTube channel on the TV. And she just watched, and watched, and watched. Am I supposed to support my wife? All she ever does is work and watch TV. Why can't I do that? Why is my life so hard, and she can just live in gleeful ignorance of everything!

What a lazy couch potato! She'll become fat one day! And when I said that to her, chaos was all that was intelligible. Chaos. Oh, what a word that is. One simple word, yet it captures so much. Lingering within my thoughts is funner than I thought. It is like a chaotic donkey on a slide indeed, I can see why people love solo hiking so much.

As I continued walking along the muddy and curvy trail, I started to notice the elevation starting to change. The damp weathered rocks became more visible as the muddy trail became steeper and steeper. Feeling a slow lingering sense of uneasiness fell upon me, I instinctively reached out into the breezy air to hold onto the damp, almost disgusting trees, just to keep my balance as I navigated through the trail. These trees were getting more abundantly present across the landscape, and it gave me an enclosed feeling.

Looking around, I can see that I need to keep an eye on everything I am doing. This is just more precarious than I imagined it would be. And while looking around for sturdy trees to hold onto, I saw for a glimpse a red robin. A red robin. I like red robins, their chirps are like soothing, yet affirmative. I can onllllyyyyy…. Ahhhhhhhhh! (Thud) I rolled down the pathetic hill. I rolled, and rolled, and rolled.

It felt like a cancer gripping onto me, all of this mud! Ahhhrrrrr! I hate this! Ahhhhhhhhh! Ugh! Huh? It stopped? I must have rolled four feet down the muddy hill. Oh no! My shoes! They are brown! Brown? I paid $60 bucks for these shoes! $60 bucks! How can I replace these shoes now? I can't use these for work now. Ugh!!!

Rising up like a defeated phoenix, I looked onward, and I thought about my life back home, and I just knew I must go on. As bad as it is here, at least it's not my wife. Oh…. Yes. The fall colors were calling their secrets in a way my wife never did. So, I looked around and noticed that the chocolate candy bar my wife gave me before I left, which was in my pocket, fell on the ground. Oh…, I really wanted to snack on that!

But I simply cannot litter, it's wrong. Therefore, I grabbed the muddy chocolate bar, half-melted and gooey, and I tried to get as much mud and goo off of it as I could while putting it back in my pocket, since I had nowhere else to put it. In the muddy mess, I was happy to see that the path was less steep ahead. So, I walked with a somewhat upright posture within the colorful old-growth trees of the forest.

The colors of the leaves seemed to go on endlessly and endlessly. As if they were a blob of color on the canvas that is my sight. I walked through the trail, as dead leaves crunched under my feet after every step. The whole atmosphere just has this mysterious feeling all around me. The wind echoed within the trees, making sounds reminiscent of lumberjacks from days gone by. Yet, nonetheless, I walked, and walked, and walked.

Looking at the trees whilst I walked reminded me of my Grandpa. Time is just a shadow of what came before, and here later. My Grandpa always said that during our family dinners. Eating pot pie and ice cream desserts. And he was always

drunkenly blabbering about how his pot pie was meant for him. Now, he is dead. I guess that pot pie just wasn't meant for him.

Shaking my head with a grinning face of disappointment, I tried to refocus my attention towards my surroundings. I am slowly realizing that now—not before—I am deep within the damp forest. Looking at the dawn sun, I thought to myself about how dawn is the best time for wildlife, and how cool it would be to see a deer out here. Suddenly, as if my thoughts commanded it, I heard leaves starting to crackle, and it got louder, and louder, and louder. A slight sense of tingling went down into my stomach. Is there a criminal out here? A lost pet? Mouse?!

At last, I saw it come out of the tree line and it showed itself. “It is a deer!” I quietly proclaimed. The deer looked as if it was skinny, but that's normal for any deer. Yet, wouldn't it be amazing if I could get a picture with the deer and post it on my Instagram? Oh…. It would be so good. Think of all of the people that will be impressed. I might even get a laugh from my boring old wife.

So, I thought, like a crow over a carcass, of a way to get the deer closer to me. While I was thinking, I instinctually put my hands in my pockets, and I touched my half-melted chocolate bar. Reaching for it out of my pocket, it was almost wet to the touch. Looking at it with a face that would make a mom laugh and scream, I thought. Yes, deer like food, I can give the deer my chocolate bar. It can save me the mess too.

It is a win-win. Of course, I can feed a hungry deer, who wouldn't? So, I directed my chocolate bar at the deer. As I directed it towards the deer, the deer looked back at me, and slowly walked towards me. It felt as if I was the guardian of the forest. Protecting life, wherever I go. It was a surreal feeling indeed.

As my vision was partially covered by my melty chocolate bar, I could see through the edges of my chocolate bar a wondrous sight. That deer is coming closer. Its slightly crooked gaze looked at me with intent. Intent. Intent of a magical magnitude that I could not explain. So, I was drawn in towards the beauty of the deer that came before me. As the deer slowly came closer, the cloud cover lightened, revealing the sunlight as it became filtered through the leaves of the

trees.

It is beautiful. As I stared at the heavenly fall light, I felt a slight pull on my hand. It is the deer! I quickly refocused my attention towards the deer, and my chocolate bar was in its mouth. Its mouth moved side to side. Chocolate covered the sides of its mouth as it licked the juices off of its tender lips. The deer then looked at me with a stare of what I can only think of content. The deer was so beautiful.

Skinny, but fit-looking. As if it was built by nature. Suddenly, the deer did a quick jolt-like reaction, as it turned its head and bolted off the path and into the deeper fall forest.

Chapter 2

Fall

I looked around my surroundings and I saw nothing. No deer, no signs of any animals, outside of birds and trees. As if it was just a dream. Oh man, I don't even know anymore! Confused and curious, I decided to continue on my hike as I looked for that deer along the trail.

As I walk, I feel my legs start to ache as my feet lunged forward more and more. The ground is changing from heavy leaf cover to rockier, more bare ground. The trail also became more steep and precarious the further I walked.

As I went down in elevation, I saw a wet rocky ravine span across the landscape. Gasping in wonder. All I can feel was excitement. Oh…. I am so excited to show the world what I just found!!! This is amazing!! So, with a sense of dramatic urgency, I went down the trail. As I went down the trail, the path became more rocky, more precarious. It is soo precarious, to the point that I was struggling to even place my feet on the wet ground. Oh…. I wish that this trail would be easier, it is a good view, but is it that good? The wet rocks are also no hel…….. Ahhhhhhhhh!!!!!

(Thud)

Suddenly, the darkness slowly lifted away? Huh? I gradually looked around bewildered. Where am I? The sun is in a different location within the shining sky? How long has it been? Shaking in confusion, I began to look around. I felt a slight

ringing in my head, but I saw no blood or felt any sharp sensation of pain whatsoever.

Oh… Hoooooo man! Did I just fall? Man, that was close. I guess I slipped on the wet rocky cliff, as if my life was not my own anymore. I must have hit my head on a rock or something. Looking up, I could see that I had fallen to a flat surface ten feet down on the trail.

Looking behind me, I could see the end of the rocky ravine, its steepness came out of nowhere. Oh, what would my wife think of me? Probably nothing. Why would I even care about what a nobody thinks of me? I thought I would love her at the start, but love is a curse. A curse of bliss, yet like all curses, they end. And when love ends, that is when the curse is lifted. Maybe she still has the curse? Maybe so. I cannot fully know if she does, but if she does, I am sorry for her. For she is too lazy to elevate herself out of the bliss that is taking her life away.

At least here, it is not bliss. It is real. I screamed into the empty forest whilst climbing down the wet rocky ravine, “No one can fool me here!” Indeed, nothing can fool me. Nature has no ulterior motive, it just is. I can even take a break from the memory of Grandpa's craziness here.

As I slowly looked around, I saw that a waterfall stood in the not-so-far distance, brown with the materials it carried, yet powerful in its turret that it cascaded along. It came down from the top of the rocky ravine and fell to the bottom of the red, brown, and green forest below. A racing river flowed along the bottom across the peaceful trees. As I maneuvered across the wet rocks, I finally found flatter ground that led down to the bottom. The trail was relatively flat, yet steep. Yet, it was not steep enough to hurt anyone's stride, just steep enough to see its elevation change in one glance.

As I walked down the trail, I looked around and wondered why had I come here? My face was grinning at the peace I was witnessing. At this moment, I knew I made the right choice coming here. My thoughts of my wife almost faded into the background, as I walked through the bottom of the rocky ravine. Looking around, I tried to find that deer that I had seen. Yet, I couldn’t find it in the forest or on the

top of the rocky wet ravine. I couldn't find the deer near the river, as the trail went around next to the aggressive riverside.

The riverside is long, vast, and wide. I can see the other side, looking back at me like a mirror, yet raw in its unhinged composition. The trail is wet, muddy, and flat. It is gross. Very gross. I tried my best to avoid every little ounce of slop that I could. Soo gross. I must tr…….. Wait, what is that in this distance? As I turned my head towards the object, I could start to see a black blob become visible about thirty feet in front of me. It was covered by a slight curve along the trail, as the trail left the aggressive riverside towards the wooden landscape beyond. Curious, I decided to walk towards it.

As I came closer, the leaves riddled the ground around my feet more and more. The wind felt as if it was picking up, and the river raged with a loud sound, nearly covering my thoughts. My footsteps became more erratic as my balance grew harder to maintain. I can see the first hints of brown coming from the crooked-looking thing. It looks like, well I don't know what it looks like. A bag? A purse? Fur?

As I grew closer, my curiosity only grew stronger and stronger. The silhouette-like shape slowly became more concrete and conformed. It was getting harder to walk as I came closer to it. I don't know why? It felt deep, like a hole that I could not see. Reaching across from the turn on the trail, I…… Oh!!! Oh, no!!!! It's a dead deer! Why is a deer dying here? It should have died in the river or something.

I looked around it and noticed that it was skinny, yet it looked fresh, as if it had died recently. Looking, I saw no visible scavenger marks, and then I looked at its mouth. Black. Its mouth is black. Mold, I guess. I mean deer can mold, right? So, I reached my shaky hands to touch the mold on the mouth, and when I touched it, it was not stiff like mold, it was wet and gooey. It was chocolate. Shaking, I couldn't believe what I was seeing. Is this the deer?

Why?!! No. That is impossible. It was so happy, so content, so beautiful. How can this happen? I was just trying to help it?! Hurrrrrr!!!!! It was her. She did this! If

my stupid wife didn't give me that cholesterol infested chocolate bar, then maybe this deer wouldn't have died from diabetes or something.

She might be crying like a baby that lost its way, but I am not? I slowly stared at the eyes of the dead deer. I saw….. Wait? What do I see? Its eyes had what looked like a crooked residue of life within them, yet it looked dark inside. It creeps me out. Yet, nonetheless, the deer is dead. Yet, I am perplexed at those eyes? Is it alive? Can it be dead and alive at the same time like a shadow?

Of course not, that's stupid. Yet, if only I was not married, then maybe this deer would still be alive. Wait….. If the deer is dead because of my marriage, then am I at fault? No… that cannot be. How can I know that a deer will die due to a marriage? Yet, if so, then this deer is innocent. And if it is innocent, then uhhh maybe…. am I at fault? Ooooooo!! I have no idea?! Why???!!! Why is this deer dead?! Why?!

As I cried in confusion, my cries were loud, but were drowned out by the sounds of the raging river. It was as if the world was comforting me, but silencing my confusion. Yet, it is not working? The river may rage, but the deer is silent. It is beautiful, but not because the river is clear, but because, well, I don't know why. I just feel it somehow. I feel the wind, leaves, river, and birds, and they are loud, very loud. Annoyingly loud. I don't understand. I don't understand? Why is this deer dead? Why?!

Why does everything have to be like Grandpa? Why? Dead. Dead…. Dead? Gone in the wind, yet creeping out the living with such overwhelming residue.

I couldn't handle the sight of such a disgrace, so I decided to turn around and walk away from the slightly smelly corpse.

Chapter 3

The Weight of This Past

Every step I took was like a ground mole being transcendent, but looking at dirt every time. Frustrating, yet exhilarating. Not in a good way, but in a confused, lost way. The strong cool wind made each step a challenge to undertake. The leaves fell behind me as the river roared its loud cry. The sky was bright, but I could tell from the sun that it was mid-day. Yet, not a soul was in sight. Am I at fault?

As I frantically looked around the wet rocky ravine, the whole environment was telling me….. Yes? No!! An environment cannot tell me anything! I tell myself what I ought to be! I screamed at the wet rocky ravine as I walked out of it, “You are not the boss of me! You are not my Grandpa!”

Wait…… Grandpa? Is this Grandpa? No. Impossible. I don’t believe in ghosts. It just makes no sense, if one is to die, then how can they be present now? Is that deer present now? Grandpa did always say that time is just a shadow of what came before, and here later. What does that mean? Oooooooo….! What does that mean? How is he here? How?

In a state of confused frustration, I tried to climb out of the wet, rocky ravine. It was a trail, but a very elevated trail. It is soo elevated that it felt like a climb more than a hike. The sweat on my face burned my eyes as I stared up at the blazing sun. This ravine was weird, disgraceful? Yet, oddly compelling. Each time I reached up to the next level, I gained a slight growth in confidence within me. So, I did it

again, I climbed, and climbed, and climbed. After a great and endless strife upon my stride, I finally reached the place where I had previously fell. It looked to be ten feet high. Taller than a sick giraffe from my perspective.

Yet, I could not stop! I must continue to climb. So, I reached as far as my arm could reach to the nearest protruding rock, and I lifted my body up as I tried to reach the top. As I climbed, I slowly started to see the top of the ten-foot cliff. Awww yes! I think I am doing it! Suddenly, I heard a heavy crunch, not like eating potato chips, but like stepping on them. And then I felt a quick sensation of weightlessness, and before I knew it, I felt a sharp sensation of pain on my knee. I fell. I fell? Looking up at the sky, I wondered why? Why?! Why is this hike not going my way? All I wanted was to take a break from all of this stress! Ooooooo!!! What would Grandpa think of me now? Would he be sad? Upset? Happy?

Wait……. The raging waterfall, the falling leaves, the gusts of wind all around me. Isn't this a sign? A sign of what? What could it be? Time is just a shadow? What on Earth is that all about? Wait……. Wait…….. The deer. The deer's life is now nothing but a shadow. Yet, when I saw those eyes. No. There must be more! If I die, will my eyes be like that? I hope not! I have so much life in me. It just cannot be true. It cannot be true! It cannot! Yet, that deer is dead. And as death comes, it takes, but those eyes did not look like death, a residue was within them. I saw it!

But how?! How!? How. Hrhrrahhhhh!!!! I screamed at the sky, at the fall-colored trees, those dying trees, all around me was death, and yet, something more was around me. Something more. Something more. Yes. Something more is here. Time is a shadow of what came before, and here later. That is what my Grandpa always said to me on those boring family reunions.

Yet, of what came before? Like of a life gone by? Maybe in those eyes I saw nothing? Can one feel nothing? Now that's nonsense. What came before? What did I do before? Live? Of course. I lived. I lived. A life lived? And here later? Isn't that…. The residue!

What on Earth! How can he know? He must be controlling things. Grandpa must be ruining my hike! He is the culprit!! Yet, I cannot get this sting off of me. This feeling of more. This. This…. What is this? When I looked into those eyes, what was it? Life? Death? Beauty? No. I simply saw a deer. No. I saw a deer that lived. Wait? I was seeing the deer's past in its present eyes? If that is the case, then what is death? Can we even die? I mean, maybe that is so. Yet, a life gone is a life gone. You cannot live when you are dead.

Yet, if I was the deer, would that matter? If I was the deer? Weird. Wait…… Where am I? I should just get back up and get over this stupid rocky step. So, I slowly stood back up, lightly unbalanced, especially on my knee, but I could still walk. As I looked around my surroundings, I saw a rough, rocky overhang next to the rocky step. It looked like a gate, as walls of rock were between this rocky step. So, I then reached towards that overhang, like how a mother reaches towards their child, and it gave me enough leverage to reach to the top of that inconceivably hard rocky step.

I finally sighed in relief, as I walked up to the top of the ravine, towards the wooden forest above. As I walked, the rocky walls dissipated into the vast open sky. This ravine is such a challenge. No wonder people avoid this place. As I walked out of that wild ravine, I looked back at it. Looking at the vast landscape of the rocky slopes, the fall-colored old-growth trees, and the raging waterfall and river, I said out loud towards the beauty, "Weird." I then slowly turned back, and with a slight limp to my stride, I walked away from the ravine, and into the wooden forest beyond.

Chapter 4

Once Dead, But Now I See?

As I walked into the woods, the fall colors brightly shined everywhere. Leaves fell, and crunched under my limping feet. The trail became less elevated and more flat as I progressed along it. Looking around me, I saw nature. I saw the beauty of it. The beauty. The beauty. The beauty. The eyes! The deer! Oooooooo! Those stupid eyes! What if those eyes were mine? Oh, what if that was so? Would I be still alive?

If I was the deer, would it matter if I died? How would I know? Would it even be death to not know? Those eyes! Oooooooo! Those eyes! What are those eyes?! If I was the deer, then my experience of life would likely end, like how the leaves decay away into the soil. Yet, why do I not cry for the leaves like how I cry for the deer? Why?! I slightly laughed at such a thought whilst I walked through the dense leaves.

Oh….. This drag is real. As if the leaves were trying to keep me here forever. Just like the deer! Oh… Grandpa! Don't take me! I am not ready yet! I want to live! I want to be, not to become!

I want to not be just a shadow, but here in the now. Yet, ain't I already becoming? No. I am not! What's changing, my mind? No. I am not my mind. I am me. I am me. I am me. Keep it together, Yofferaon. I am me! Wait……. Crunching over the leaves, the sound of death was upon me. Dread was coming from the trees to haunt me. Yet, keep it together, Yofferaon! When a leaf becomes soil, does the leaf

die, or does the leaf merely lose its own shape of what it is?

Its identity might change, but its identity is not the same as its life. I feel it, the life of the leaves are everywhere. The eerie glow of the forest is not death; it is life, as a new identity. Oooooooo!!! What about that deer? That deer isn't going to have a new identity, it's dead. Right? If that deer is like a leaf. Alive. Then, the deer lives in those eyes. Yet, didn't I kill it?

Well, the deer killed itself, let's be real here. Ohhhhhh…… If only I didn't give that deer my wife's chocolate bar, then none of this would have happened. That deer would still be alive and I would have had a peaceful hike. Isn't that what the good is all about? To be happy and to experience life? And yet, my experience has not ended. I am alive. But the deer? What is it now?

Ohh…. I cannot change what I did. Wait…….. I cannot change what I did…… Birds chirped all around me as I walked with the stride of a decrepit old man. As I walked up a pathetic slightly elevated leafy slope on the trail, I thought about why I cannot change what I did. I cannot change what I did to that deer. It felt hopeful, even after all of what had happened to that deer. Within history, that deer will always follow its desire, and eat that chocolate bar.

At least it died in delight. Yet, having a past doesn't mean that one is alive, right? A shadow is not the same as what comes later? A shadow. A shadow….. Why a shadow? Isn't life supposed to be bright? How can a shadow be bright? Looking at the bare old trees as I walked, I saw their shadows. They are all unique, all particular to each individual tree. All particular? Why? Why…….. Isn't it because a shadow can only exist because of the past? To what creates a past? Life. A life lived is what creates a shadow? It is! It is! That is what Grandpa was talking about!

The deer is not dead; its identity will change, but its life will always exist as it particularly was. The past of the deer is the deer. To be the dead deer means to experience no distinction between past, present, and future. It is to be, not to become.

Wait….. No. That's nonsense! To be dead is to be dead! How can I live in the past when I experience the present? Does my experience even matter? Or am I more than what I experience? What is more? Being? Haaaaaa!?!?!?!? To be? Why are you back? You are like a shadow mirroring a tree in the woods. Trying to be something you are not. My past cannot be me? My past mirrors who I am? Crazy. Yet, if I am to be what I am, then what I experience as me, is not grounded in time, but in what I was, is, and is to come. What I be is what I am…….?

And in to be, my actions create who I really am—not superficially, but experientially, physically, and in every part of me. My actions? My actions….? That hits. Oh….. that hits. Wait……. If my action to let that deer eat that chocolate led to its death, then isn't that decision forever a part of me? Oh no! Oh no!!!!! I screamed, I cried, I yelled at the forest, "You are killing me! You monster!" I cannot change who I was. And because of that, that deer is dead. Yet, I don't want to change. I love myself. I love to be me. I don't want to experience me, I want to be me! That is all that I want. I want to be good. Yes…. I want to be good.

Can I be good? Can I be good to the dead deer? Was I good? Was this hike good? Oh… I don't know! I want to be good! Yet, to be good is to not kill. Yet, I killed that deer. I killed it. No. My marriage did. My wife gave me that melted chocolate bar. She gave it to me. I need to be good, but her; she's something else entirely.

I saw the end of the rough dirt-like trail coming closer to me. Feeling a sense of accomplishment, I turned my gaze, full of fear and fearlessness at the same time, upward. I looked up towards the blue sky. Whilst looking up, I looked around me: the birds chirping endlessly, the sky brightly above me, and ground calmly existing below. Where am I?

And out of the corner of my eye, I saw a red robin. I like red robins. I looked at that red robin. Its wonderful call was soothing. It is life. It is beautiful. I stared into its eyes, and I could only see life, and yet I see not just any life, but a life lived. Such richness was like a candle flickering for hours in the darkness. Maybe life is meant to end. Not because dying is good, or that dying even exists at all.

But maybe, just maybe, what makes me me at all is that I lived. Not that I am

living, or will die, or have been born, but simply that this moment is real, along with all that has preceded it and all that will follow. That eternal chain will never break, for I am walking, and when I walk, I can never unwalk it ever again.

This hike. This hike is not just any old worthless hike. This hike is this hike. That's why everything happens because everything on this hike is what makes this hike what it is. What it is… And what is that red robin? Oh…. That red robin is life, that red robin is beauty. That red robin is telling me something? What? What are you telling me? I stared at the red robin, but I must have startled it, since it quickly flew away into the distant blue open sky.

Flew. It flew, like how my wife flew from me. Is that good? Is my wife good like the red robin that calls me? What is the good, but simply my connection with the red robin. Connection… That is so wondrous to be. Soo beautiful…… In awe, I instinctively moved my head downwards, towards the eyesight of the trail, and walked away from my friend. Yet, no matter the storm, I hope that I will never forget him.

I could see my old rustic car in the distance, but I now know that at least that old trashy car is my old trashy car. Looking at the parking lot of the trail, I saw fallen leaves everywhere. It was full of history, full of life, yet no identity anywhere. It is so overwhelming like if the sky suddenly fell without warning.

Ahhhhhhuurrrrrr!!!!! What if I just forget all of this? Forget that I ever went on this hike. I could, but can I? Can I really forget about this hike? I can forget my wife tho, right? My wife. My oh my, my wife. She is still a part of me? Yet, I so wish she wasn't. Just like how I wish that deer didn't die. Oh no. Oh…. What would my wife think of me now? She probably thinks of me being lazy, going on this hike instead of cleaning the house.

Being lazy? But she is the lazy one! Lying on the couch, watching TV. What life is that? Well, I guess it's her life. Her own particular life, as worthless as it is. But me. What about me? Wait…… Oh….. Oh……. What have I done!!! I can never get my morning back! I can never get it back…….

Oh…… I wish my past was different. I wish that deer would be friendly to me. Yet, if all that were to be true, would I still be me right now? Still be me? I wouldn't even be thinking of this right now if that stupid deer didn't die on me!! To erase my suffering right now would be to change me now. I don't want that. What would happen to me? Would I still be me? No. I would rather be me. I would rather be me.

Crying like a baby who just lost a game, I knew I hadn't just messed up. I had ruined myself. I abandoned goodness; I abandoned the red robin for myself, and I do not want to go back.

Who cares about my wife? She's gone. I have become my wife, and in doing so, I abandoned myself. Yet, I feel nothing. I still feel like me, and I want it. I don't care if she is winning, and she has been winning all along, but should I be winning or living? I don't know. All I know is that I already made my choice. Is this what death feels like?

I guess I already know what that deer felt; it is not nothing. It is not even brief or painless. It is like riding a shaking old car, complaining about how bad life is when life is showing you such epic beauty at every step along that way. Shaking my head in disbelief, I turned my attention away from this weird hike, and as I clicked my car keys, I thought to myself, I was once dead, but now I see.

About The Author

My name is PhilosophizingDoodle, and I wrote *Walk* over two weeks in early October 2026. The imagery of my work called *Walk* was inspired by my own hike at Hocking Hills, Ohio. Yet, the fall atmosphere of rural Michigan inspired me to write this story and explore my philosophy of Respectivism. The two inspirations worked together to form this beautiful work of art. Through *Walk*, I hope to explore what makes love, beauty, and the good possible, and what role our particular lives play in living a good life.

I am not going to tell anyone how they should feel while reading *Walk*, since every reader should have the right to experience their own particular experience within *Walk*. However, I believe that our world needs to reconsider what it means to live a good life. Too often, we treat goodness as though it were simply a matter of happiness, comfort, or perfection. I disagree.

One does not need to be a Hedonist to be beautiful and good. A life does not need to be perfect to be meaningful, and I wonder whether focusing on our perfections is the wrong way to see the coherence of the good. I refuse to be a Hedonist and be cynical about our universe. I refuse to make my goal solely happiness when suffering is real. I believe everyone needs to consider the possibility that our mistakes do not make our lives worthless or incomplete. Perhaps even within the histories we cannot erase, there remains the possibility of becoming something more coherent than before.

For me, particularity—the lives we have lived—is deeply connected to the possibility of love, beauty, and the good. Perhaps the good is found in the coherence of a life lived, in the irreversible particular history that makes each of us

who we are within space and time. Maybe what makes the good meaningful as the good is that our histories, and the histories of everything that relates to everything else, cannot be replaced or erased, even if we want them to be.

And if your particular history were changeable, then you would likely not be who you are right now. And that is what matters the most. You. A different suffering is not just a different suffering, it is a different you entirely. But what does that mean for who we are right now? Can we separate ourselves from our past, or is it more deeply connected to us than we realize?

And if our lives were different, would the good still be the same to us? I do not think these questions are easy to answer. Our lived lives are part of what makes us who we are, and I wonder whether the reality of our past gives our lives a meaning that we often overlook. Perhaps the good is impossible without you, without Yofferaon. We suffer because we exist, but perhaps suffering does not have to prevent us from being good. Perhaps it is possible to be good, even when we cannot simply experience it as happiness.

This is what I wanted to explore through Yofferaon's walk. As he encounters the damp forest, the deer, and the mysterious red robin, he begins to question what it means to live, to die, to be himself, and to be good. He struggles to understand whether his actions have made him a bad person and whether he can ever escape the weight of his own history.

Through these struggles, I wanted to explore whether the good might be something other than perfection, and whether our particular lives and the mutual connections we share with reality reveal something about what it means to be good. Yet, I will leave it to the reader to decide what Yofferaon discovers, and whether his conclusions are enough for you.

I know that a 24-year-old writing about the meaning of goodness might sound a little pretentious. But I am living, and that is enough of a motivation for me to write. I wonder whether learning to understand our imperfections might help us better understand the lives we have lived and the good we might yet become part of. Accepting ourselves does not mean pretending that we have done nothing

wrong. It means reaffirming our own entire existence and taking control of our destiny, so that we all can be like the red robin that flew. The good is not one action; it is a way of life in relation to the lives we have lived towards the ascent of a more mutual existence with reality.

Through writing *Walk*, I hope to participate in the very good that I advocate for, and to inspire others to do the same in their own unique ways.